Hinduism spread, it accommodated earlier forms of worship rather than overthrowing them. Similarly, many tribes revered animals, but instead of disrespecting them, Hinduism absorbed the non-humans too, by making them the companions or vehicles (*vahanas*) of the gods. So Vedic gods found themselves riding a lion, mounting a peacock, reclining on a swan, or sitting on a bull. It was part of the agglomerative nature of Hinduism that it neither rejected nor dismissed the faiths it encountered, but sought to bring them into the fold in this way.

Hinduism, therefore, has given birth to a rich iconography, varying according to the specific divine form and further according to the role in which that divinity is depicted, whether at a peaceful moment or in an attack upon evil, for instance, or whether as 'Himself' or transformed for a specific purpose (Vishnu, for instance, became half-man half-lion, Narasimha, to kill a demon who could not be killed by a human). While the iconography of Shiva, Vishnu and the 'remover of obstacles', the elephant-headed Ganesha, is well known, every depiction of Ishvara (in whichever form) involves certain symbolic images and attributes, and the images of these gods were configured to embody profound conceptions of the universe, from the subduing of ignorance and the defeat of evil to the harmonies of destruction and regeneration.

Thus Brahma, the Creator, is always shown with four heads, facing all four directions, as befits the creator of the universe; he holds the Vedas in his hand, a prayer-vessel beside him, and sits on a lotus, the favoured flower in Hindu iconography since it remains pure and unsoiled by the mud and dirt from which it emerges. His consort is Saraswati, goddess of learning and wisdom, who is always depicted holding the musical instrument the *veena*, symbolising the music of the cosmos, the inner sound of Om from which the universe emerged. She has rosary beads in one hand to signify the importance of prayer and meditation, and palm leaf scrolls in another, to epitomise learning. She too sits on a lotus, but sometimes on a peacock, a symbol of the ego that should be suppressed in the pursuit of true knowledge, and her *vahana*, or vehicle, is the graceful swan.

Brahma is rarely worshipped—there are barely a handful of temples dedicated to him, the most remarkable at Pushkar in Rajasthan—but